THE PIANO BUTLER



Handbook

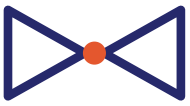
Everything behind the music you play: reading, rhythm, expression, scales, chords, harmony, shape and style, from your first lesson to Grade 8.

WITH THE WORKBOOK, THE APP AND READ & LISTEN

This book belongs to

My teacher

I started on



THE PIANO BUTLER

Handbook

Music theory for pianists,
from the first lesson to Grade 8

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The Piano Butler Handbook

Draft edition, November 2026

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The music examples are drawn from works in the public domain (traditional tunes and composers who died more than 70 years ago), newly engraved for this book.

Piano Butler is independent. It is not affiliated with, or endorsed by, any examination board. Grade levels in this book are a guide to the order in which ideas are usually met.

The Read & listen narration uses computer-generated voices.

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THE PIANO BUTLER HANDBOOK

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

Welcome

This book explains the music you play: what the signs on the page mean, why a piece sounds the way it does, and how to play it well. It is the whole picture in one place, for you to dip into whenever a piece asks a question.

Who it is for

1. **Students** from the first lesson to Grade 8, reading with a teacher or a parent, or on their own.
2. **Adults** coming back to the piano, who want the reasons, not only the rules.
3. **Teachers** who want one clear explanation of each idea, with exercises to match.

Three promises

A picture first.	Every idea starts with something you can see, then something you can play.
Said once, clearly.	Each idea has one home in this book. Other pages point to it instead of saying it again.
Always at the piano.	Every chapter ends at the keys: a ten-second Try it, a tune you know, a game.

THINK OF IT A good butler keeps the whole house in order, so that you can simply enjoy living in it. This book keeps the theory in order, so that you can simply enjoy playing.

ABOUT THIS BOOK

How the pieces fit

The Handbook is the centre. Everything else is cut from it, so an idea always looks and sounds the same wherever you meet it.

The Handbook
the whole picture, by topic

The Workbook
two pages to write in for every chapter: Learn, then Use

Read & listen
every chapter read aloud, the page moving with the voice; scan a code or open it in the app

The house
in the app: the chapters in the order you need them, a floor for each level, a room for each step, with drills

Level books
one floor of the house in print: one spread per room, then practise

Which one when?

WHEN YOU WANT TO…	USE
understand an idea, or look it up	**the Handbook**
check you really know it	**the Workbook**
hear it explained, at home or on the bus	**Read & listen**
know what to learn next	**the house**, or your **Level book**
practise it until it is easy	**the drills** in the app

ABOUT THIS BOOK

The levels

The house in the app puts the chapters in the order you need them, one floor for each level. Here are the floors, with the Handbook pages for each room. In the chapters, “First met: Level 0” means the Beginner floor, “Level ½” Prelim, and “Level 1” to “Level 8” Grades 1 to 8.

Beginner

Sitting and hands, the keyboard and the staff, beat and note values, loud and soft, and fingering.

Posture and hand shape	18–20
The keyboard	22–26
Fingering	163–164
The staff and the clefs	27–28
Pulse, tempo and the bar	50–52
Notes: the crotchet	53–55
Notes: the minim	53–55
Notes: three beats	53–55
Notes: the semibreve	53–55
Loud and soft	76–78

Prelim

How to practise, reading the notes, how long a note lasts, time signatures, repeats, touch, major and minor scales, and your first chords.

Practising well	165–166
The staff and the keyboard	29–31
Reading the notes	32–35
How long is a note?	56–58
Time signatures	59–61
Repeats and road signs	71–73
Touch: smooth, short, strong	79–81
Major scales	93–95
Minor scales	96–98
Chords and triads	110–112
Review	

Grade 1

Ledger lines, sharps and flats, intervals, key signatures, 6/8, speed words, four kinds of triad and sight-reading.

Ledger lines	36–38
Sharps, flats and naturals	39–41
Counting intervals	42–44
Keys and key signatures	99–101
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Speed words	82–84
Four kinds of triad	113–115
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THE LEVELS · CONTINUED

Grade 2

Major, minor and perfect, upbeats and triplets, finding the key, the pedals, chords in a key, motifs and phrases.

Major, minor and perfect	45–47
Rhythm: groups and upbeats	65–67
Finding the key	102–104
The pedals	85–87
Chords in a key	116–118
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Grade 3

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Grade 4

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Chords under a melody	142–143
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Grade 5

Form, styles through time, chords from outside the key, progressions and performing.

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Chords from outside the key	136–138
Progressions everywhere	144–145
Notes outside the chord	175–176
Performing	171–172
Review	

Grade 6

Seventh chords and slash chords, and cadences by ear.

Seventh chords	122–124
Slash chords	131–133
Review	

Grade 7

Colour chords (Extra), and every earlier chapter a step further.

Colour chords	125–127
Review	

Grade 8

Tall chords: 9, 11, 13 (Extra), and every earlier chapter a step further.

The tower: 9, 11, 13	128–130
Review	

A room marked with a second title, such as “a step further”, comes back to a chapter you have met before and goes one step deeper. The rest of the chapter can wait for its own level.

ABOUT THIS BOOK

Meet the cast

You will hear these voices in Read & listen and meet them in the Think of it boxes. Each one stands for an idea, so the idea is easy to remember.

The Butler
YOUR GUIDE

Explains every chapter, calmly, one step at a time. He is never in a hurry.

Clara
THE STUDENT

Asks the questions you might be thinking, and sometimes gets them wrong, so you do not have to.

The Queen
THE TREBLE CLEF

Rules the high notes. Her curl wraps round line 2, the note G.

The King
THE BASS CLEF

Rules the low notes. His two dots sit either side of line 4, the note F.

The Doorkeeper
THE KEY SIGNATURE

Stands at the start of every line and reads out the sharps or flats for the whole piece.

The Guest
AN ACCIDENTAL

Arrives in one bar wearing a sharp or flat hat, and leaves at the bar line. A natural: the hat comes off.

The Stationmaster
THE TIME SIGNATURE

Checks the ticket: how many beats in each carriage, and that every carriage is full.

ABOUT THIS BOOK

For parents

You do not need to read music to help. Ten minutes, twice a week, is enough.

Each week

1. **Listen together.** Scan the code on this week's page, or open Read & listen in the app. Most rooms take three to five minutes.
2. **One page to write.** The Workbook or Level book page for the same room. The first answer is always done, as an example.
3. **Ask one question.** "What is the secret?" If your child can say the red box in their own words, the room is learned.

Good to know

IF…	TRY THIS
the page looks hard	Read only the secret and play the Try it. The rest can wait for the lesson.
your child is tired	Listen only, no writing. Hearing it once already helps.
you missed a week	Do nothing extra. The teacher will pick it up in the lesson.
your child asks something you cannot answer	Write it down for the teacher. A good question is worth more than a right answer.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Ask: "Show me."

After any page, ask your child to show you the idea at the piano. Teaching it to you is the best practice there is.

ABOUT THIS BOOK

For teachers

The book is built so that theory happens at home and the lesson stays at the piano. Set one room a week; check it in two minutes.

In a 30-minute lesson

WHEN	IF THE ROOM WAS DONE AT HOME	IF IT WAS NOT
First 2–3 min	Check the page; ask for the secret in the student's own words.	Read the secret and the Example together (3 min).
Next 2 min	Find the idea in the piece being learned.	The same: always in the piece.
The rest	Pieces and technique.	Pieces and technique.
Last minute	Send the next room.	Send the same room again, with the next.

Good habits

Five minutes at most. If theory was not done, it never takes more than five minutes of the lesson.

Always in the piece. The idea is found in the music the student is playing, every week.

One room at a time. The house orders the rooms; a Level book prints one floor.

Reading the boxes in a lesson

BOX	USE IT FOR
The secret	the two-minute check: can the student say it in their own words?
Example	the three-minute catch-up when the room was not done
Try it	a warm-up at the start of the lesson
Game	a group lesson, or the last two minutes
Trap	when the same mistake comes back in a piece

Not sure where a new student fits? Use the **Handbook check** in the app, a short quiz that names the first chapter to read, or **Where do I start?** on p. 14.

ABOUT THIS BOOK

Where do I start?

You do not have to start at page 1. Find your place, then read from there.

IF YOU ARE…	START AT
brand new to the piano	**Before you play**, p. 18, then the Beginner floor
reading simple pieces already	the **Handbook check** (free, in the app): it names your first chapter
preparing for a grade	your floor in **The levels**, p. 9
stuck on one thing in a piece	the **Glossary and index**, p. 179, or the Tips page at the end of each part
coming back after years away	each Part's **opening map**: read the secrets only, and stop where they stop making sense

The part openers

Each Part opens with a map: every chapter in one line, with its secret. Read a map in two minutes and you know what the Part holds.

A good week

1. **One room.** Listen once, read the page, write the Workbook page.
2. **Find it in your piece.** The idea is somewhere in the music you are playing.
3. **Drill it for five minutes** in the app, on two or three days.

THINK OF IT A map does not walk for you, but it stops you walking in circles.

ABOUT THIS BOOK

My practice week

Copy this page, or draw your own. Tick a box each day you practise.

	MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	SUN
30-second check	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Warm-ups	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
This week's room	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Scales	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
My piece	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Something just for fun	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

This week

Room

Piece

One thing to fix

My teacher says

ABOUT THIS BOOK

My questions

Write down anything you want to ask in your next lesson.